launching a nuclear bomb, as if to suggest that Vajpayee and his government did not know what they were doing. The disproportionate dependence of the Chinese on the Left parties in India, with whom the Chinese embassy in New Delhi maintained regular liaison, also influenced their thinking. The Chinese may have thought that the Left had not been as enthusiastic as the rest of the political spectrum about the nuclear tests. The Chinese possibly presumed that the internal political differences might be utilized to influence the direction of India's policy towards China in the post-May 1998 situation. Since their understanding about India was not up to date, the Chinese policy of 'cooling and isolation' could not achieve the desired outcomes. As a result, the Chinese were unable to exploit domestic differences while, at the international level, the ring-fence that the Chinese had tried to create through a unified P-5 stand and the UNSC Resolution 1172 also began to rupture as Indian diplomacy started to work.

India's efforts with the Americans began to show progress. Indian negotiators played on American pragmatism to get them to adjust to the new reality while holding out unspecified assurances of meeting benchmarks set by them on nuclear non-proliferation. In his recollection of the events in the summer of 1998, Michael Krepon has written on how Jaswant Singh kept the ball in play with the Americans with private assurances, without ever vocalizing them in public. [32] Strobe Talbott subsequently acknowledged this in his own book saying, 'Its [India's] strategy was to play for the day that the United States would get over its huffing and puffing and, with a sigh of exhaustion or a shrug of resignation, accept a nuclear armed India as a fully responsible and fully entitled member of the international community.' [33] India also judged—correctly as it turned out—that if it remained steadfast long enough to get the US to shift its position, it would only be a matter of time before